Ease: A Regime Theory of Joy

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Version 1.0

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Abstract

This paper proposes that intense positive affect ("joy") is not produced by reward, learning, or goal-directed activity, but emerges from a distinct control regime, termed the *Ease regime*. Access to this regime is governed by a threshold variable (Z), reflecting the degree of evaluative monitoring and optimization. When Z is high, cognition operates in an evaluation-dominated mode characterized by continuous correction, goal orientation, and performance tracking, constraining affective intensity. When Z falls below a critical threshold, evaluative processes fail to stabilize, allowing discrepancies to remain informational and enabling access to high-intensity positive affect.

Entry is abrupt, unambiguous, and not preceded by gradual improvement, consistent with a regime shift rather than a learning process. A central blocking mechanism, Z_shift, is identified as a self-reinforcing loop in which attempts to recover the state induce persistent monitoring that prevents re-entry. The model predicts a measurement paradox: methods that recruit self-monitoring suppress the phenomenon they attempt to observe.

The framework offers a falsifiable alternative to reward-based and training-based accounts, positioning joy as a threshold-dependent property of system dynamics rather than an outcome of optimization.

This Is Not Jhana, Flow, Meditation, or Reward

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This document is intended to prevent immediate misclassification. What is described on this document, the *Ease regime*, is often mapped to existing categories. These mappings are incorrect.

Not Jhana
Requires sustained attention, training, stabilization.
Ease: appears when monitoring drops, collapses under stabilization attempts.

Not Flow
Task-optimized, performance-linked, improve with repetition.
Ease: anti-instrumental, collapses under goals and repetition.

Not Meditation
Practice-based, repeatable method.
Ease: non-repeatable, repetition reinstalls monitoring and, similar to the Flow comparison, collapses the state.

Not Arousal / Excitement
High activation, often linked to anticipation or stakes.
Depends on escalation .
Ease: can emerge at low or neutral arousal .

Not Reward / Pleasure Seeking
Driven by acquisition, consumption, or reward prediction. Scales with intensity or novelty of stimulus.
Ease: does not scale with reward magnitude.

One key difference is that Ease becomes accessible when **evaluative processes fail to stabilize.** Ease is a regime in which discrepancies remain informational rather than being rapidly converted into corrective demands. In other words, it requires a suspension of optimization, rather than the pursuit of an outcome.

Body Signal Pipeline

What joy feels like in the Ease regime

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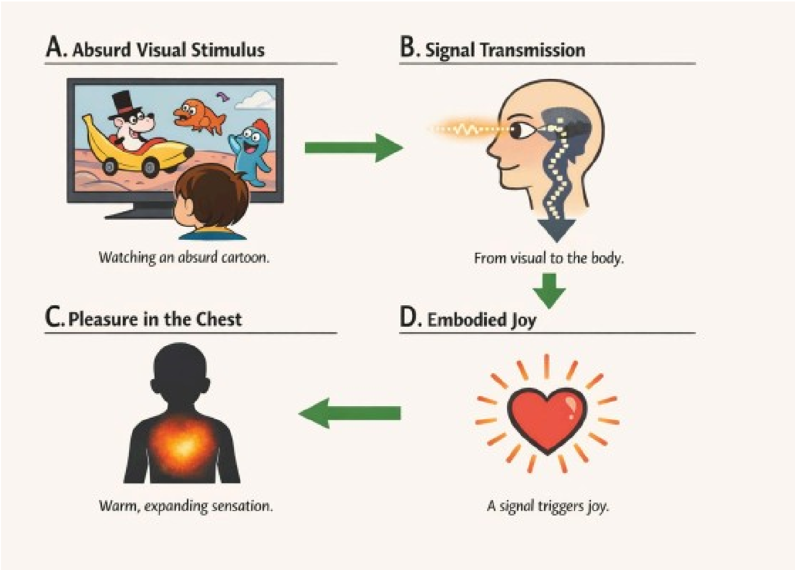
Pipeline of Joy Within the Ease regime:

Prediction error → joy

Event: A prediction error in a cartoon is perceived by a subject with the Ease regime already unlocked.



Result: A chest-centered pleasure, sometimes radiating to the head, commonly interpreted as "joy."

High-salience visual features, such as brightness or treasure-like qualities (e.g., glow, rarity cues), also influence the intensity of the state. A second mode can coexist: **the state of being moved.** This one is typically elicited by slow-tempo, low-frequency music, including very simple, almost childish melodies. **It is often accompanied by a diffuse, brownish, grain-like visual texture.**

This Is Not Nostalgia: Ease as Reactivation of Encoded Affective States

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The Ease regime may reactivate intensely positive early-life experiential configurations, not as ordinary memory, **but as a reopening of a previously inaccessible state.**

For example, if someone used to play marbles as a child, merely seeing a marble years later with the Ease regime may bring back the original feeling from that period with striking immediacy. This is not nostalgia. Rather, it is the return of the way the scene was originally encoded. The same sensory tone, affective quality, and bodily feeling can reappear together. Importantly, this does not have to be voluntarily produced. In fact, it cannot be forced, and in some cases **it cannot even be resisted**, because the feelings arise automatically. It is also accompanied by chest-pleasure,

Highly positive moments in early life are often stored together with rich contextual features such as odors, sounds, and visual atmosphere. Under the Ease regime, these configurations may be reactivated as a coherent whole, in a process resembling hippocampal pattern completion. In this sense, the Ease regime may restore access to experiential states many people assume are permanently lost.

All-or-None Entry into the Ease Regime

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When the regime appears, it is abrupt, unambiguous, and immediately recognized. No ambiguous or “maybe” cases appear.

The phenomenological profile described above is not used as proof of mechanism. Competing explanations including immersive distraction generate distinct, testable predictions.

Entry into the permissive regime is not gradual but abrupt. The transition can occur as a clear regime shift, characterized by a sudden and sustained elevation of positive affect **that may persist for hours.** The intensity of the resulting state can be **unusually high**, sometimes approaching a level that feels difficult to tolerate. This is not merely an increase in pleasure, but a global reorganization of experience, often reported as a precise phenomenological return to childhood-like affective accessibility. There is an **uncanny, even slightly evil feeling** in the first few hours.

The shift is not limited to hedonic tone. It is frequently accompanied by simultaneous changes across multiple domains, including heightened reward sensitivity, increased emotional lability, vivid imagery and imaginative capacity, **spontaneous laughter,** and a general amplification of experiential salience. It is experienced as self-sufficient and non-teleological, yet its contrast with ordinary adult experience can be so extreme that it produces immediate and unambiguous recognition.

Threshold vs Learning

Learning predicts:

- gradual improvement
- performance correlation
- reproducibility

Ease model predicts:

- discontinuity
- independence from skill
- unpredictability
- generalization

Joy as a Phase Transition System

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Joy is not produced by inputs, actions, or optimization. Joy is a regime-dependent phenomenon. It is a regime property conditional on **Z being below a critical threshold**.

Z reflects **an active system that maintains evaluative control** through continuous comparison and correction.

The system is governed by a critical value, Z_**threshold**.

- If Z > Z_threshold → the system remains in an evaluation-dominated regime.
- If Z < Z_threshold → the system becomes permissive to the Ease regime.

This **threshold**, therefore, defines a qualitative change in system behavior:

From Evaluation-Dominated Regime (Z-high)

- Continuous monitoring
- Goal-directed behavior
- Performance tracking
- Error correction
- Narrative integration

In this regime, positive affect is weak, unstable, and dependent on outcomes

To Suspended-Optimization Regime (Ease, Z-low)

- Suspension of evaluation
- Absence of optimization
- Decoupling of action from instrumental outcomes
- High sensitivity to structured input

In this regime, **high-intensity positive affect** becomes accessible.

Anti-Instrumentality

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Any attempt to use, optimize, or reproduce the state increases evaluative load and pushes the system back above the threshold.

Therefore:

- Goals destroy access
- Repetition destroys access
- Measurement destabilizes access

This framework is incompatible with:

- reinforcement **learning** models
- performance-based theories of **flow**
- training-based **meditation** models

Because all of them rely on optimization, which increases Z.

Interventions must target control structure, not affect directly**:** interrupting monitoring, breaking optimization, blocking narrative capture. It's not large, explicit goals that block access, but the continuous stream of micro-corrections applied to experience as it unfolds.

Stimuli modulate intensity, but **do not produce the state.** Optimal stimuli create small surprises without forcing the brain to rethink everything.

Good example : Music videos:

- high prediction error
- low requirement for causal coherence

The difficulty in maintaining joy's intensity does not lie in finding activities. That part is trivial, but in preventing those activities from becoming instrumental.

The intensity question becomes relevant only once the Ease regime has already been unlocked.

The Measurement Paradox in Affect Research

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Measurement paradox: when access depends on reduced evaluation at entry, measurement procedures that recruit self-monitoring can suppress the phenomenon itself. Common practices such as real-time ratings, introspective prompts, and performance framing may therefore produce false negatives. **Ease behaves like a target that disappears under explicit detection.**

Observation as Interference

- being observed → blocks entry
- reporting → blocks entry
- instructions → block entry

Standard experimental setups systematically prevent the phenomenon they attempt to measure.

Measurement is not passive; it is a direct Z_ctx amplifier.

To mitigate this, the model predicts that:

- post-hoc measurement should increase observed entry probability,
- behavioral proxies can detect regime shifts without direct evaluation,
- blind-to-hypothesis designs reduce anticipatory monitoring and increase access.

Explanation is not neutral, it is a control-mode intervention.

Adult Surprise as Behavioral Marker

Adults:

- immediately report it

This becomes:

- a **measurement proxy**

Spontaneous reporting is a valid marker of regime transition.

This reframes inconsistencies in affect research as potential artifacts of measurement-induced regime collapse.

System Dynamics

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The system is not continuous:

- Below Z threshold → access possible
- Above Z threshold → impossible

And importantly:

- the transition is **nonlinear: positive affect operates under threshold constraints, not linear accumulation.** Regime accessibility is probabilistic.

This aligns with:

- phase transitions
- bifurcation systems

Z accumulates through structural, contextual, and historical factors.

- When Z is high, monitoring stabilizes and blocks access to the Ease regime.
- If Z is sufficiently reduced, monitoring fails to stabilize.
- The system crosses the threshold.
- The Ease regime becomes accessible.
- Monitoring may re-enter at any moment, producing collapse.
- Once the threshold is crossed, the state becomes stable and resists to evaluative collapse

The system is entry-limited, not stability-limited.

Three-Layer Blocking System

- **Z_acc** → slow accumulation (lifetime exposure to evaluation and goal enforcement)
- **Z_shift** → structural loop ("checking for joy")
- **Z_ctx** → situational load (transient increase in closure demand from context)

Regime collapse = f(Z_acc, Z_shift, Z_ctx).

Regime accessibility depends on multi-scale constraint stacking. Under high Z, discrepancies are rapidly resolved through categorization, evaluation, and goal-directed behavior. Under low Z, discrepancies remain temporarily unresolved, permitting the emergence of non-instrumental, high-intensity positive affective regimes.

Monitor ≠ Evaluation: it's a Self-Protecting System

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Important distinction:

- monitor = mechanism
- optimization = behavioral regime emerging from it

Optimization is not a choice, it is a mode induced by persistent monitoring.

The monitor is: continuous, self-reinforcing, always comparing
So evaluation is the default stabilization layer.

Monitoring is a control-layer process that converts discrepancies into actionable signals by assigning them corrective relevance and preparing optimization, even in the absence of overt behavior. Evaluation is an observable manifestation of monitoring, not its core mechanism. **The proposed control structure may not be directly measurable without altering the phenomenon.** The empirical target is therefore not monitoring itself, but its behavioral signature: abrupt entry, sensitivity to evaluative framing, disruption by repetition, and dissociation between access and skill acquisition.

Monitoring is self-reinforcing via reward hijack:

High Z feels serious, competent meaningful where in contrast, low Z feels illegitimate and unserious.

The optimization regime is self-stabilized through reward. As a result, a large portion of affective life is non-interpretive and systematically erased by evaluation.

Joy is Only Fragile at Entry

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Joy collapse corresponds to re-entry of a control layer that arbitrates valuation.

What kills the state:

- "this is good"
- "how long will it last"
- "what does it mean"

Meta-evaluation is sufficient to flatten affect without changing input or reward tone.

The system has asymmetric stability: hard entry, easier re-entry.

- entry fragile
- **once opened → partially self-sustaining**

Technical details: Hysteresis

→ Ease is a hysteretic regime in which the authority of evaluative processes depends on state history. Entry requires the suppression of corrective authority below a higher threshold, while persistence tolerates its partial return. Collapse reinstates authority in a way that prevents immediate re-entry, even under conditions that were previously sufficient.

Z_shift is the central, modifiable blocker:

- wanting joy → checking for joy
- checking → permanent monitoring

Z_shift = transition from occasional checking → automatic anticipatory monitoring

Critical moment

The true transition to the evaluative regime probably around the teenage years is not gradual but tied to a realization, the moment the system detects that the state does not return when expected. → **Z_shift = emergence of anticipatory testing → Childhood-joy subjectively vanishes.**

Childhood = Default Ease Regime

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Children:

- tolerate inefficiency
- no negative tagging

Adults

- **error → correction**

Children are not "better at joy", they are not yet in **optimization regime**. Negative tagging, not error itself, is what tightens the system. Play stabilizes open dynamics by preventing premature closure.

So, children are:

- low Z_acc
- no Z_shift
- low Z_ctx

Ease = baseline. Here, **development is a regime transition**, not a capacity gain.

Children don't report Ease because of « **Quiet Affect »:** Affect can exist without becoming an object.

- So affect exists but
    - is not labeled
    - not narrated
    - not amplified

Double Masking of Loss

1. It disappears
2. It was never labeled

→ so:

- no memory of loss
- no language for it

Ease disappearance is cognitively untraceable due to dual masking.

Affective Quietude in Children And the Failure of Nostalgia

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Does it mean children are all hiding a secret? Children tend to hide the phenomenon because, when it is frequently present, it does not register as exceptional. It is simply the manner in which experience unfolds. The child protects the regime behaviorally, but never represents it conceptually.

Engagement Without Preference

Standard model:

- engagement → liking

Ease model:

- engagement can exist with: no liking, no reporting and no preference

When the system is still learning what kinds of patterns exist at all, stimuli function as openings in model space, not confirmations of an already-known world. The resulting positive affect feels vivid not because it was louder, but because it was not preempted. Once explanations are in place, perception becomes suppressive, surprise attenuates, and repetition suppression dominates. Before that closure, perception is expansive, exploratory, and structurally transformative.

Standard models assume:

- error → resolution → learning

Ease:

- error can persist indefinitely *if closure is not enforced*

This also clarifies why nostalgia so often fails to restore the phenomenology it seeks.

Nostalgia operates through comparison and recognition. It explicitly references a prior state and evaluates the present against it. In doing so, it reinstates the very monitoring and narrative framing that prevent the original regime from forming. The attempt preserves the image of the past while dissolving the mode that made it possible. The analysis distinguishes childhood ease from regression, sentimentality, and hedonic intensity. It proposes instead that its defining feature is affective quietude. Ease, in this sense, is not marked by emotional excess, excitement, or heightened arousal. **It is characterized by the absence of internal noise, commentary, and evaluative pressure**. Childhood joy does not depend on stronger emotions, but on a quieter control regime. What defines it is not how much is felt, but how little needs to be managed.

Absurdism and Prediction Error in Cartoons

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Most cartoons are characterized by

• **weak or absent resolution**
• **minimal goal-directed intent**
• l**ow or inconsistent payoff structure**

Rather than relying on classical humor mechanisms such as setup and punchline, cartoons often exhibit dense sequences of perceptual and causal violations. Physical laws are intermittently broken, proportions become unstable, characters stretch or fragment, and objects transform without warning.
From this perspective, what is commonly labeled as “humor” may, at least in part, reflect an interpretive overlay imposed by evaluative observers. An alternative account is that cartoons primarily operate through sustained prediction error and perceptual instability, i.e., **a form of structured absurdism**.
Within this framework, children’s strong engagement with cartoons may not simply reflect immaturity or preference for humor, **but could indicate access to a regime in which discrepancies remain informational** rather than being immediately converted into evaluative or corrective demands.

Importantly, children don’t report joy when watching cartoons, because of what we like to name here « **Affective Quietude** ».

Affective Quietude

- weak
- localized
- non-verbal
- non-categorical

→ but still real: **Affect can exist without amplification, categorization, or reportability. Prediction error does not require resolution to sustain engagement. It requires the absence of enforced closure.**

→ Z modulates the probability that prediction error is closed vs propagated.

Noise vs Coherence Distinction

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Positive affect inducing-drugs:

- reduce constraints
- but introduce noise / dissociation

Fail to produce:

- stable regime shift

Ketamine, which is also associated with reduced ACC-related activity and rapid antidepressant effects, does not reliably induce a stable joy regime despite its positive affect enhancing properties. This dissociation suggests that lowering ACC activity or other structures is not sufficient for threshold entry. The result may be relief, flexibility, or affective elevation, but not the coherent, structured, and self-sustaining regime shift described in Ease. In this sense, Ease predicts that entry depends not only on reduced ACC-like control, but on how that reduction is achieved: selective suspension of evaluative micro-optimization within an otherwise intact perceptual and salience architecture, rather than global disruption.

This distinction clarifies why mechanistic neighbor evidence from ACC inhibition is compatible with the model, yet does not collapse it into a simple inhibition account.

Reducing control is insufficient if signal coherence is degraded. Global neural suppression cannot replicate structured control-release transitions.

Additionaly, another hypothesis worth exploring is tolerance may reflect in part anticipatory control, not reduced reward sensitivity.

Morin Z-Reduction Task

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This is not just “a task”.

It’s a **discriminative protocol between two models**:

- Learning model
- Threshold regime-shift model

M-ZRT is not just an induction method, it is a falsification device for gradualist explanations.

***hard signature*:** repeated failures, abrupt onset, qualitative jump, generalization persistence, beyond stimulation: True regime access is not task-bound, it alters the global control configuration. **The existence of repeated failure followed by discontinuity is itself evidence of a gated regime.**

Trying to reduce evaluation → increases evaluation → so: Control over monitoring must be **indirect, or it reinstalls itself.** Any stable protocol tends to become **its own failure mode.**
Monitoring loop → blocks entry

- M-ZRT → disrupts loop
- → threshold crossing

Within the M-ZRT, two brief exercises may be preferable to one, because a single perturbation can remain too weak or ambiguous, whereas a longer sequence risks becoming structured, repeatable, and therefore reabsorbed into optimization. Two may be sufficient to interrupt motor continuity without forming a stable routine.

A valid task is: no goal, no metric, no evaluation, no repetition, no expectation.
Example: With Unreal Tournament or Quake, no HUD or ignore it: While playing, meaning while actively playing and moving your character, imagine a picture, and only notice when it fades. Then do an ugly shoulder movement: not a dance, but a disordered, non-rhythmic move. At that point, drink a sip of coffee, and the task ends. Not more than 1 try per day.
How monitoring re-enters: anticipatory commitment, premature closure, performance checking, meaning generation, correction, salience veto, expectancy resolution

Morin Z-Reduction Task: Types of exercices

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Openness refers to acts that weaken immediate goal closure or deliberate control. In your sequence, the imagined picture fits openness because it introduces a low-purpose mental object that is not being used to solve the game. The key is not to maintain it successfully, but only to let it exist and notice its disappearance. That keeps the act away from performance.

Exemple: While moving in-game, briefly think of something incomplete, like “what if…”, without finishing the thought. Do not try to answer it, do not come back to it. Just let it exist once and keep playing. The point is that nothing is resolved, nothing is used, and nothing is checked.

Salience refers to making one element briefly stand out without turning it into a goal. The fading of the image is a salience event, because attention is captured by a small internal change. The ugly shoulder movement also fits salience, especially if it is deliberately non-rhythmic, slightly disordered, and useless. It becomes a brief sensory-motor marker rather than a skillful action.

Exemple: While playing, pick one sound, for example a distant weapon noise or a footstep, and treat it as if it were the only important sound for a few seconds. Not because it is useful, just because it stands out. Then drop it without transition. The point is a temporary amplification of one element, without turning it into a goal.

Suspension refers to interrupting normal optimization or continuous strategic flow. The ugly shoulder movement helps here too, because it breaks motor continuity and introduces a moment that does not serve winning, aiming, routing, or combat efficiency.

Exemple: While moving forward, suddenly stop for no reason, stay still for a very brief moment, then resume movement in a different direction without correcting or explaining it.

Openness introduces something unforced, salience makes something briefly stand out, and suspension interrupts the normal evaluative flow. M-ZRT can be designed by combining those three in different proportions.

M-ZRT is probably best described as a **hybrid salience-openness sequence with a suspension ending**. **The target configuration is not low activity, but decoupled salience without control.**

This is a structurally falsifiable regime theory, not a vague phenomenology.

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A. Entry barrier

- metrics kill entry

B. Threshold / lock-in

- early fragile, late robust

C. Methodification

- repetition curve inverted

D. Z

- predicts entry, not persistence

Repeated failures

- abrupt onset
- qualitative jump
- generalization
- persistence beyond stimulation

The existence of repeated failure followed by discontinuity is itself evidence of a gated regime.

This directly opposes:

- skill learning
- habituation
- simple arousal models

Repeated failure is not noise, it is a structural signature of an entry barrier. True regime access is not task-bound, it alters the global control configuration.

Discussion and Conclusion

The present framework proposes that high-intensity positive affect is not the outcome of reward accumulation, skill acquisition, or sustained practice, but the expression of a distinct control regime defined by the temporary failure of evaluative stabilization. This shifts the explanatory focus from content and stimulus properties to system-level dynamics governing access conditions. In this view, joy is not produced, but becomes accessible when monitoring and optimization processes fall below a critical threshold.

This perspective challenges dominant gradualist models. Learning-based accounts predict progressive improvement, reproducibility, and performance dependence. In contrast, the Ease framework predicts discontinuity, independence from skill, and abrupt transitions following repeated failure. The existence of such discontinuities, if empirically confirmed, would support a threshold-based model over incremental learning explanations.

A central contribution of the model is the identification of a structural blocking mechanism (Z_shift), whereby attempts to access the state induce anticipatory verification that stabilizes into persistent monitoring. This loop provides a parsimonious explanation for the difficulty of voluntarily re-entering high-intensity positive states despite intact reward systems. Importantly, it suggests that the primary obstacle is not insufficient stimulation, but the presence of a self-sustaining control process.

The framework also introduces a methodological implication for affect research. If access depends on reduced evaluation at entry, then common experimental practices such as real-time reporting, introspective prompting, or performance framing may systematically suppress the phenomenon under investigation. This “measurement paradox” implies that some inconsistencies in the literature may reflect methodological interference rather than true absence of effect. Approaches relying on post-hoc reports, behavioral markers, or reduced hypothesis transparency may therefore be more appropriate for capturing regime transitions.

The account further offers an alternative interpretation of childhood affect. Rather than reflecting heightened emotional capacity, children may operate in a low-evaluative regime in which affect is not continuously monitored or categorized. This could explain both the apparent intensity of early-life experiences and the difficulty of recalling or reproducing them in adulthood. In this context, phenomena often described as nostalgia may fail not because the underlying representations are lost, but because the control regime required for their reactivation is no longer accessible.

At the stimulus level, the model predicts that environments rich in structured prediction error, such as cartoons or music videos, are more likely to modulate the intensity of the state once the regime is accessible, without being sufficient to produce it.

This distinction clarifies why similar stimuli can appear ineffective under high evaluative load yet become highly potent under permissive conditions.

Several limitations should be acknowledged. The construct of Z is currently operationalized at a theoretical level and requires empirical grounding through measurable proxies. Additionally, while the framework emphasizes control dynamics, its neural implementation remains underspecified. Candidate mechanisms may involve interactions between salience, monitoring, and control networks, but this remains to be tested. Finally, the phenomenological reports described here, while consistent, require systematic validation under controlled conditions.

Future work should focus on developing experimental paradigms capable of detecting discontinuous regime transitions without inducing evaluative interference. The proposed behavioral protocol (M-ZRT) provides a starting point for such investigations, particularly as a falsification tool against gradualist accounts. More broadly, this framework suggests that access to high-intensity positive affect may depend less on optimizing inputs and more on altering the conditions under which the system ceases to optimize.